

URL Discovery, Validation & Data Visualization – Summary

Overview

This assignment focused on three core objectives: discovering official government meeting URLs, validating an existing masterlist, and visualizing link availability across departments and platforms. The goal was to improve the accuracy, reliability, and usability of public meeting data for analysis and scraping purposes.

Methodology

1. URL Discovery

Official base URLs were identified for City Council, Planning Departments, and Zoning Boards across both meeting videos/audio and minutes. Discovery was done using targeted search queries such as “*city name + city council meetings*” and by navigating official municipal websites.

Only verified government platforms were used, including:

YouTube, Legistar, Granicus, CivicClerk, Swagit, and AgendaCenter.

Each URL was documented along with notes describing how it was found—through direct search, internal website navigation, or platform-specific search.

2. Validation of Masterlist

Each URL in the masterlist was reviewed and categorized as:

valid, broken, replaced, duplicate, or iframe-based.

- Broken or outdated links were replaced by locating the correct base URLs through official city sources.
- Iframe-based links (e.g., CivicClerk, BoxCast) were flagged appropriately since they function in embedded systems but may not open directly in browsers.
- Duplicates and mislabeled entries were corrected by verifying the actual department content.

This ensured the dataset remained accurate and reliable for automated workflows.

3. Data Visualization

Three charts were created to analyze link availability and platform distribution:

1. Link availability across four department types
2. Comparison of Planning Department video links versus other departments
3. Platform-wise distribution of links (YouTube, Facebook, Granicus, Legistar, Swagit, AgendaCenter)

These visualizations helped highlight coverage gaps and dominant hosting platforms.

Key Findings

- Planning Department meetings show lower availability of video/audio links compared to other departments, indicating gaps in public access.
 - YouTube, Legistar, and Granicus are the most commonly used platforms for hosting government meetings.
 - Several entries in the original masterlist were outdated, duplicated, or mislabeled, which could negatively impact automated data collection if not corrected.
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Issues Identified & Resolutions

1. Broken and Outdated URLs

Resolved by navigating official city websites to identify the correct current meeting pages.

2. Iframe-Based Links

Instead of marking them as broken, these were labeled clearly as iframe-compatible to avoid incorrect classification.

3. Duplicates and Mislabeled Entries

Corrected by verifying actual page content and aligning each link with the appropriate department.

Conclusion

This process significantly improved the quality and usability of the dataset by ensuring that URLs are accurate, clearly categorized, and well-documented. The visual analysis further provided insight into platform trends and transparency gaps, making the data more actionable for scraping, monitoring, and product workflows.